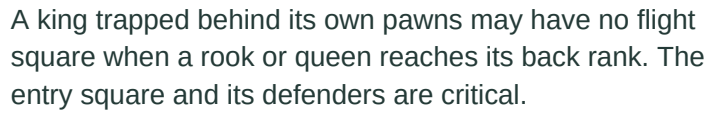


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on c1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.

Previous move: 23.Rxf7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

23...Be3+ 24. Kb1 Rd1#

23...Be3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **24.Kb1.**

24...Rd1# Mate: rook on d1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.